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Seventeen people have died in US immigration custody this year, ICE says

By Ted Hesson

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Federal agents with U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) conduct an immigration enforcement operation in Pine Grove, Minnesota, U.S., January 28, 2026. REUTERS/Shannon... [Purchase Licensing Rights](#) [Read more](#)

April 18 - At least 17 immigrants have died in U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement custody from January 2026 through early April, according to ICE. That follows 31 deaths last year, a two-

decade high.

Aled Damien Carbonell-Betancourt

The Reuters Iran Briefing newsletter keeps you informed with the latest developments and analysis of the Iran war. Sign up [here](#).

Died: April 12 at a federal detention center in Miami

Nationality: Cuban

Age: 27

A federal officer discovered Carbonell-Betancourt in what ICE described as an apparent suicide attempt at the detention center, according to a statement from the agency. The officer called a medical emergency, staff began cardiopulmonary resuscitation, and City of Miami Fire Rescue personnel continued resuscitative efforts after they arrived, ICE said. Miami Fire Rescue pronounced Carbonell-Betancourt dead about an hour after he was discovered, ICE said.

Alejandro Cabrera Clemente

Died: April 11 at the Winn Correctional Center in Winnfield, Louisiana

Nationality: Mexican

Age: 49

Cabrera was found unresponsive at the detention center, ICE said, and staff attempted to resuscitate him. He was taken to a local hospital where, after further life-saving efforts, he was declared dead, according to ICE.

Tuan Van Bui

Died: April 1 at the Miami Correctional Facility in Bunker Hill, Indiana

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Nationality: Vietnamese

Age: 55

Bui was found unresponsive and declared dead at the scene, ICE said. The cause of death remains under investigation.

Jose Guadalupe Ramos

Died: March 25 at the Adelanto ICE Processing Center in Los Angeles

Nationality: Mexican

Ramos was found unconscious and unresponsive in his bunk by security staff, ICE said. The staff called on-site medical personnel and he was transferred to an area hospital where he was declared dead, ICE said.

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Royer Perez Jimenez

Died: March 16 at the Glades County Detention Center in Moore Haven, Florida

Nationality: Mexican

Age: 19

Perez Jimenez's death was a presumed suicide, ICE said, while the official cause of death was under investigation after he was found unresponsive in the early hours. The detention center's staff unsuccessfully tried to resuscitate him for nearly 10 minutes after he was found, according to ICE.

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Mohammad Nazeer Paktiawal

Died: March 14 at the Parkland Hospital in Dallas, Texas

Nationality: Afghan

Age: 41

Paktiawal, an Afghan immigrant who previously worked with the U.S. military in Afghanistan and later sought asylum in the U.S., died in ICE custody less than 24 hours after being detained in Texas, a U.S. veteran-led advocacy group said.

In a statement, ICE said Paktiawal was eating breakfast when medical staff noted that his tongue had become swollen, prompting a medical response. He was declared dead only after multiple attempts at resuscitation, the agency said.

Emanuel Cleeford Damas

Died: March 2 at a hospital in Scottsdale, Arizona

Nationality: Haitian

ICE took Damas into custody after he was arrested on assault and battery charges in September 2025 in Boston, ICE said. Damas was transferred to the Florence Detention Center in Florence, Arizona. ICE

said he reported shortness of breath on February 19 and was sent to a local hospital and then transferred to a Phoenix hospital and placed in an intensive care unit.

He was intubated on a ventilator the following day and died on March 2, with the cause unknown, ICE said. In an interview with the Associated Press, his brother said he had died due to an untreated toothache and related infection.

In response to a request for comment, the U.S. Department of Homeland Security referred to ICE's public statement, which did not mention any dental issue.

Pejman Karshenas Najafabadi

Died: March 1 at a hospital in Natchez, Mississippi

Nationality: Iranian

Age: 59

ICE took Karshenas into custody in April 2025 after he was convicted of fentanyl possession, the agency said. He had several chronic health conditions but remained detained and was transferred in October 2025 to the Louisiana ICE Processing Center, a facility opened under the Trump administration, according to ICE.

On February 20, 2026, ICE health staff evaluated him again and he was then transferred to a hospital for long-term care, where he went into cardiac arrest on March 1. He was transferred to the Merit Health Hospital in Natchez, Mississippi, where he was pronounced dead, ICE said.

Alberto Gutierrez Reyes

Died: February 27 at a medical center in Victorville, California

Nationality: Mexican

Age: 48

Gutierrez was arrested by U.S. Border Patrol agents in Los Angeles in January, ICE said. He reported feeling faint on February 25 and was admitted to Victor Valley Global Medical Center for chest pain and shortness of breath, ICE said. He became unresponsive and died on February 27, ICE said.

Los Angeles City Council member Eunisses Hernandez said in a statement that her office had been in touch with his family and that he had been denied medical care while in ICE custody.

In response to a request for comment, the Department of Homeland Security said comprehensive medical care is provided to everyone in ICE detention.

Jairo Garcia Hernandez

Died: February 16 at a hospital in Miami

Nationality: Guatemalan

Age: 27

ICE took Garcia into custody after he was encountered by local police near Rochester, New York, on January 21, 2025, the agency said. ICE said he was immunocompromised and was "already in ill health" when he was detained. On February 16, 2026, more than a year after he was taken into custody, he collapsed unexpectedly and died, according to ICE.

Lorth Sim

Died: February 16 at the Miami Correctional Facility in Miami County, Indiana

Nationality: Cambodian

Age: 59

Sim entered the U.S. as a refugee in 1983 but had been ordered deported following several convictions, ICE said. He was detained after arriving at an ICE office in Boston on December 30, 2025, and then transferred to the Indiana detention center, the agency said.

ICE staff found Sim unresponsive in his cell on February 16 and he was pronounced dead by staff and emergency personnel, ICE said. It said that the incident was under investigation.

Victor Manuel Diaz

Died: January 14 at Camp East Montana in El Paso, Texas

Nationality: Nicaraguan

Age: 36

Staff at the detention center, which is located on the grounds of Fort Bliss, found Diaz unconscious and unresponsive in his room on January 14 and he was pronounced dead shortly after, ICE said. ICE said the incident was under investigation but that he died of "presumed suicide."

Heber Sanchaz Domínguez

Died: January 14 at the Robert A. Deyton Detention Center in Lovejoy, Georgia

Nationality: Mexican

Age: 34

Sanchaz was detained by ICE after being arrested in Georgia for driving without a license, ICE said. He was found "hanging by the neck and unresponsive in his sleeping quarters" and later pronounced dead at an area hospital, ICE said. The agency said the incident is under investigation.

Parady La

Died: January 9 at a hospital in Philadelphia

Nationality: Cambodian

Age: 46

ICE said La was being detained at the Federal Detention Center in Philadelphia after a January 6 arrest and was being treated for "severe drug withdrawal" when he was found unresponsive in his cell. He was transferred to Thomas Jefferson University Hospital, where he was diagnosed with brain and organ failure and declared deceased on January 9, ICE said.

Luis Beltran Yanez-Cruz

Died: January 6 at a hospital in Indio, California

Nationality: Honduran

Age: 68

Beltran was arrested by federal immigration officers in Newark, New Jersey, in November, according to ICE. At some point, he was moved to the Imperial Regional Detention Facility in Calexico, California. On January 4, he complained of chest pain and was transferred to a hospital where he died two days later, ICE said.

Luis Gustavo Nunez Caceres

Died: January 5 at a Houston-area hospital

Nationality: Honduran

Age: 42

Nunez was arrested during an immigration operation in Houston on November 17, 2025, ICE said. He was eventually taken to the Joe Corley Processing Center in Conroe, Texas.

He was transferred to HCA Houston Healthcare in Conroe "due to an exacerbation of congestive heart failure" on December 23, 2025, ICE said. After "multiple life-threatening medical emergencies," he was pronounced dead on January 5, ICE said.

Geraldo Lunas Campos

Died: January 3 at Camp East Montana detention center in El Paso, Texas

Nationality: Cuban

Age: 55

Lunas died on January 3 in Camp East Montana, a detention site opened by the Trump administration on the grounds of Fort Bliss in Texas, according to ICE. The agency initially said he experienced "medical distress" and that they were investigating the incident.

The Washington Post reported later that month that the local coroner would likely rule the death a homicide. The Post also interviewed a detainee held at the Camp East Montana site who said he saw guards choking Lunas when he refused to enter solitary confinement.

After the report, the Department of Homeland Security [issued a new statement](#), saying Lunas attempted to take his own life while detained at the detention site.

DHS said the security staff "immediately intervened to save his life" but that Lunas "violently resisted" them.

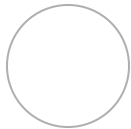
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Ted Hesson
Thomson Reuters

Ted Hesson is an immigration reporter for Reuters, based in Washington, D.C. His work focuses on the policy and politics of immigration, asylum and border security. Prior to joining Reuters in 2019, Ted worked for the news outlet POLITICO, where he also covered immigration. His articles have appeared in POLITICO Magazine, The Atlantic and VICE News, among other publications. Ted holds a master's degree from the Columbia University Graduate School of Journalism and bachelor's degree from Boston College.



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